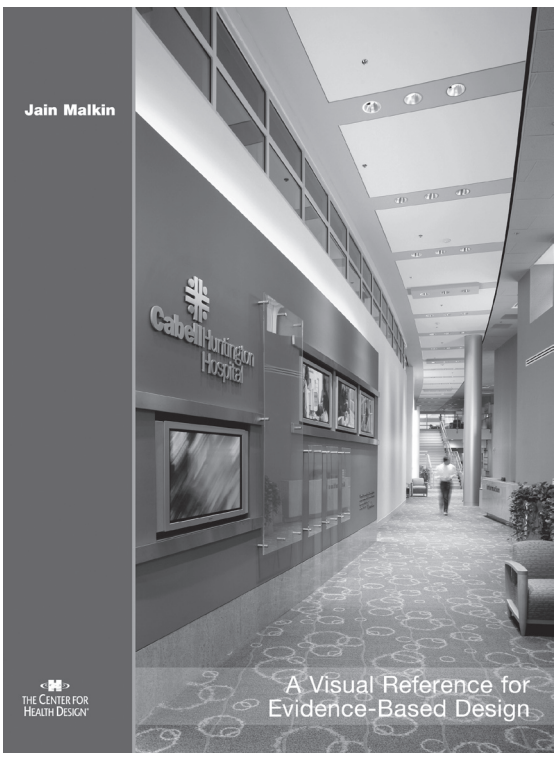
A Visual Reference for Evidence-Based Design

Book review by L. Bradford Perkins, FAIA, MRAIC, AICP

A Visual Reference for Evidence-Based Design by Jain Malkin. Concord, CA: The Center for Health Design, 2008, 350 pages, $199.00.

One of the chronic weaknesses of the design professions—in particular architecture and interior design—has been a tradition of approaching each project as a unique problem. Even worse, some of the profession's leaders and their clients believe that superior design talent can overcome a lack of experience in a particular building type. There has been too little respect for real environmental design research, too little effort put into learning from each project, too few resources devoted to capturing that knowledge in a form that can be reused, and only sporadic attempts to use that knowledge base consistently as the foundation for a more informed design solution for future projects. The cliché that a firm's assets walk out the door each evening is too true when applied to the design professions.

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Many, however, believe that the built environment can make a real difference in the quality of the lives of the people who use these buildings. Healthcare is only one such building type. Jain Malkin and the The Center for Health Design

are two of the most effective advocates for this issue. With the support of the Center, Jain has published a book that is an important contribution to the movement in the design professions to capture and build on design research and experience. *A Visual Reference for Evidence-Based Design* is a very good addition to the limited library of really useful healthcare design texts. Moreover, it is not just for architects, interior designers, industrial designers, and other design professionals. It is also written to be used by hospital administrators, medical researchers and academics, policy makers, and other healthcare professionals responsible for creating and maintaining healthcare environments.

Jain Malkin is the founder and president of a California-based interior architecture firm. She and her firm specialize in healthcare design. She is a respected national leader in the field and a prolific writer, teacher, and lecturer on healthcare environments. Thus, she is an appropriate spokesperson for the cause of evidence-based design in healthcare.

The book is organized into 10 chapters. The first five define evidence-based design, outline research methods, discuss the particular problems of patient safety and infection control, indicate how some existing research can be incorporated in design, and provide an overview of how to create a positive patient experience in a healthcare environment. The remaining five chapters discuss how to apply existing evidence-based design knowledge in five major areas: staff spaces, patient units, diagnostic spaces, treatment spaces, and spaces for patients with cancer. All chapters incorporate not only Jain's extensive personal knowledge, but also lessons learned by other healthcare design leaders. The book is extensively illustrated in color with the work of these leading firms.

I read the sections on emergency departments and cancer treatment spaces with particular interest, because they are two areas that relate to much of my own experience. The author's observations and choice of examples reflect what we have been learning from our own post-occupancy research. For example, the research she cites is consistent with the findings of our own post-occupancy analyses on the design of such important areas as chemotherapy suites. As Jain points out, the often-used approach of placing infusion patients in a single room without privacy is not a good practice. The argument that this approach encourages socialization is contradicted by the research. Though some patients like to be able to talk to others while receiving treatment, most prefer a choice. In fact, we have seen most patients opt for privacy, control of their own entertainment (TV, music, computer, and so on), and the ability to tune out. Choice and the ability to stake out personal space reduce stress, markedly improve the patient experience, and promote a healing environment. This serious book is full of commentary, specific examples, and summaries of the research on such issues. It is worth the hefty purchase price.

If the book has a weakness, it is that it does not present all of the research and lessons learned.

But this would be an impossible standard for a pioneering book. Instead, this book should be regarded as a valuable part of The Center for Health Design's Pebble Project. As they note when describing this project, "When a pebble is tossed into a pond, it creates a ripple effect." The growing list of leading healthcare providers and others involved in this project are working to demonstrate that facility design can improve the quality of care, attract more patients, attract more staff, increase philanthropic and other support, and enhance operational efficiency and productivity. All who believe that this is possible hope that the ripple becomes a wave similar to the one started by the U.S. Green Building Council and its LEED program.

I hope that this book will stimulate more rigorous post-occupancy research, more books and articles, greater client interest in evidenced-based design, and significantly better healthcare environments. *A Visual Reference for Evidence-Based Design* is a valuable and pioneering book that should be in the library of anyone with a serious interest in healthcare design.